

DECISIVE MOMENT February 2, 1943 4:00 a.m.

Stalingrad

In the early hours of February 2, 1943, the last German general still fighting in the Russian city of Stalingrad surrendered to the Soviet Red Army. At noon a German Luftwaffe reconnaissance aircraft circled over the city. The pilot radioed back to base: “No more sign of fighting in Stalingrad.” The most decisive battle on the eastern front during World War II was over.

The industrial city of Stalingrad stood on the west bank of the Volga River in southern Russia. It controlled the vital river and rail connections that carried oil supplies to the armament factories of central Russia and to the Soviet Red Army itself. The city was not the original target for the Germans. Operation Blue, the German offensive that began on June 28, 1942, aimed to capture the Caucasus oilfields to the southwest and establish a secure position on the Volga. The Soviets responded to the German advance by concentrating their forces in Stalingrad, threatening the northern flank of the German army. On July 23, Hitler ordered General Paulus and his Sixth Army to capture Stalingrad at all costs.

The assault began on August 23 with sustained air attacks. The same afternoon, German troops reached the Volga, north of the city. By September 3, Stalingrad was surrounded, with the only means of escape east across the river. The battle became intense. Stalin, the Soviet leader, had ordered “Not One Step Backward,” for this city bore his name and could never be

surrendered. Hitler was equally determined. German air and artillery shelling reduced buildings to rubble, but the Soviet troops held fast. As the Germans advanced into the city, the Russians fought them house by house. The two sides were often so close they fought each other from different stories of the same building.

On November 19, with the Russians now occupying a narrow strip along the riverbank, the Red Army launched Operation Uranus, an audacious attack on German positions from the rear. Four days later, the Germans were surrounded.

A German attempt to rescue their trapped army failed in December. The battle raged into the New Year and, worn out by constant Soviet attacks, cold, and hunger, the remnants of the German army finally surrendered on February 2. The cost to both sides was immense: since November, the Red Army had lost 479,000 men, but, crucially, German losses were also high, with 147,000 deaths and 91,000 troops captured. The myth of German invincibility was shattered. The Red Army could now go on the offensive against Nazi Germany.

Fighting for each floor

A Soviet sniper perches in a bathtub as he takes aim from a ruined building. Every inch of the city was fiercely defended. Snipers were well suited to close combat, picking off German troops one by one. They won the title of “noble sniper” if they killed more than 40.

“The **God of War** has gone over to the other side.”

ALFRED JODL, GERMAN MILITARY OFFICER, FEBRUARY 1943

